The LTTE gained global notoriety for training women and children as insurgents and were recognized as a terrorist organization by thirty-three countries. Major attacks were launched by the LTTE on civilians as well as the Sri Lankan army, which included gunfire attacks, planting bombs in planes and cars, massacres of police officers, attacks on Buddhist holy sites as well as mosques, and army ambushes.[3] They perfected the use of the suicide vest, which comprised of several bombs, worn by a lone assassin.[4] The perpetrators were the LTTE's elite suicide-bombing unit called the Black Tigers.

In hopes of resolving the Sri Lankan Civil War, the Indo-Sri Lanka Peace Accord was signed by Sri Lankan President J.R. Jayawardene and Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in July 1987. The Indian Peace Keeping Force was deployed in Sri Lanka to enforce disarmament. The accord was denounced by the LTTE, and after several months of tension, it declared war on the IPKF on 7 October 1987.[5] The last members of the IPKF left the country in March 1990 and the LTTE regained territorial control.

This was followed by the high-profile assassinations of former Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in 1991 and Sri Lankan President Ranasinghe Premadasa in 1993; both were carried out by suicide bombers. In the final months of conflict, the defence lines of the LTTE began to crumble. As the Sri Lankan army annexed the LTTE territory, the top leadership retreated and more than 100 fighters were killed. Following the death of Prabhakaran, the sole first-generation leader left alive, Selvarasa Pathmanathan, assumed the position of the new leader but was captured in Malaysia by the Sri Lankan military intelligence unit a mere fifteen days from the announcement.